ASSOCIATION OF SOUTH-EAST ASIAN NATIONS

The Association of South East Asian Nations (ASEAN) is a regional organization formed by the governments of Indonesia, Malaysia, the Philippines, Singapore and Thailand through the Bangkok Declaration which was signed by the Foreign Minister of ASEAN countries on 8th August 1967. Since then the membership has expanded and now it stands at 10. Brunei Darussalam joined on 8 January 1984, Vietnam on 28 July 1995, Laos and Myanmar on 23 July 1997, and Cambodia on 30 April 1999.

The dialogue partners are Australia, Canada, the European Union, Japan, New Zealand and the United States. Four more countries have since joined the ASEAN dialogue system: China (1996), India (1996), the Republic of Korea (1991) and Russia (1996). The United Nations Development Programme (1997) is the only dialogue partner that is not a sovereign state.

Objectives

The ASEAN Declaration states that the aims and purposes of the Association are to:

1. Accelerate economic growth, social progress and cultural development in the region.
2. Promote regional peace and stability by abiding respect for justice and the rule of law in the relationship among countries in the region and adherence to the principles of the United Nations Charter.

Fundamental Principles

The ASEAN member countries have adopted the following fundamental principles in their relations with one another, as contained in the Treaty of Amity and Cooperation in South East Asia (TAC) signed in 1976:

- Mutual respect for the independence, sovereignty, equality, territorial integrity and national identity of all nations.
- The right of every state to lead its national existence free from external interference, subversion or coercion.